

Brutal Honest Assessment — First Client Reality Check

For: Effin Fernandez (internal, never share with client) **Date:** March 26, 2026 **Context:** First client project for NeoVibe by Taurus AI

THE HARD TRUTHS

1. You've Already Done the Work Without a Contract

This is the single biggest mistake. You delivered \$15,000+ worth of work — 45 commits, 18 days, 223 assets — with no signed service agreement, no milestone payments, and no formal scope document. The client has a live, production-quality website right now. You have nothing on paper.

What could go wrong: - Client says “we thought the \$2,000 covered everything including Phase 2 and 3” - Client shares the site with another developer who clones it - Client’s governing board says “we never authorized this expense” - Your friend (who brought the deal) gets caught in the middle

Fix RIGHT NOW: - Send the Service Agreement (Document 02) TODAY - Send the Project Completion Certificate (Document 03) for Phase 1 sign-off - Send the Invoice (Document 01) with the \$4,000 figure - Get signatures BEFORE you present to the board

2. The \$2,000 → \$4,000 Jump Needs a Story

Your memory says the agreed fee was \$2,000. You're now invoicing \$4,000. This needs to be handled carefully:

Honest framing: > “The original estimate of \$2,000 was based on a standard landing page. During development, the scope expanded significantly — you requested 20+ client-annotated edits, investment tiers, governance board section, brochure download system, and comprehensive mobile optimization. The actual deliverable is 4x what was originally discussed. I'm invoicing \$4,000, which is still 60-85% below what any agency would charge for this scope.”

If they push back: You can offer \$3,000 as a “goodwill” number. Below \$3,000, you're literally working for less than an Indian freelancer's rate for this scope.

3. The Friend Dynamic Is a Liability

Your friend brought this client. That means: - You can't be as firm on payment terms (you feel social pressure) - The client may expect “friend pricing” forever - If there's a dispute, your friendship is at risk - Your friend may feel responsible if the client doesn't pay

Protect yourself: - Keep all communication professional and in writing - The Service Agreement creates a boundary between friendship and business - Your friend's role should be acknowledged but not entangled in the contract - If your friend has equity in your company, disclose this to the client

4. You're a One-Person Operation Billing as an Agency

This is not inherently a problem — many successful studios are one-person with AI tooling. But be honest about it:

What to say: “NeoVibe by Taurus AI leverages AI-augmented development, which means I deliver agency-quality work at a fraction of the cost and timeline.”

What NOT to say: “We have a team of designers and developers.” They will eventually find out, and credibility is everything with a first client.

5. The Board Presentation Is Your Make-or-Break Moment

9 board members. A bishop. A chairman. Directors. This is an audience that: - Has never hired a web developer before (probably) - Doesn't understand what they're paying for - Will ask “why does a website cost this much?” - May have a nephew/cousin who “knows computers”

Prepare for these questions: - “My nephew can make a website on Wix for free” → “A Wix site won't rank on Google, won't capture leads, won't handle the investment tier system, and won't represent the premium brand you've built.” - “Why can't we just use Facebook?” → “Facebook doesn't capture investor leads with tier selection, doesn't show up when someone Googles ‘Mater Maria Homes’, and you don't own your audience there.” - “What happens if you get hit by a bus?” → “The source code is on GitHub, deployed on Vercel, and documented. Any developer can maintain it. I'll also provide a handoff document.”

6. You Have No Maintenance Revenue Model Yet

The website is live. It needs: - Domain management (matermariahomes.com) - Hosting (currently Vercel free tier — fine for now) - Content updates (they WILL want changes) - Security patches - Analytics monitoring

This is your recurring revenue opportunity. The \$400/month retainer in your Service Agreement is where the real money is over time. $\$400 \times 12 \text{ months} = \$4,800/\text{year}$ — more than the initial project fee.

7. UAE Free Zone Tax Advantages — Use Them

Your IFZA FZCO gives you: - 0% corporate tax on first AED 375K profit - 0% VAT on exported digital services (this client is in India) - No TDS (Tax Deducted at Source) obligation — UAE-India DTAA Article 7 - International wire transfers with no forex restrictions

BUT: The client may try to deduct TDS (Indian tax) when paying you. Educate them: “As a UAE-registered entity, this payment is exempt from Indian TDS under the UAE-India Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement. I can provide a Tax Residency Certificate if needed.”

8. Questions You Should Be Asking (But Aren't)

1. **“Do you have a signed agreement with the Diocese for this project?”** — If the governing board hasn't formally authorized the website expense, your invoice may get stuck in bureaucratic approval.
2. **“Who specifically authorizes payments?”** — Is it Rajeev (Chairman)? Thomas (MD)? The Bishop? The Diocese finance office? You need to know whose desk your invoice lands on.
3. **“What's your fiscal year and payment cycle?”** — Indian organizations (especially church-affiliated) often have specific payment processing windows.
4. **“Do you need a proforma invoice before the actual invoice?”** — Many Indian organizations require a proforma first for budget approval.

5. **“Will you need a Tax Residency Certificate from me?”** — Get this from IFZA proactively. It prevents TDS issues.
 6. **“Are there any other stakeholders who need to approve the website before it goes live on the custom domain?”** — Don’t assume the board presentation = final approval.
 7. **“What’s the content plan for Phase 2?”** — Don’t start Phase 2 without written confirmation of who provides photos, copy, and floor plans. Content is ALWAYS the bottleneck.
 8. **“Have you budgeted for ongoing website costs?”** — Plant the seed for the retainer now, not after launch.
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WHAT YOU NEED TO DO IN THE NEXT 48 HOURS

1. **TODAY:** Send Service Agreement + Invoice + Completion Certificate to Rajeev Abraham via email (not just WhatsApp)
 2. **TODAY:** Present website to board. Follow the script in the Strategy Document.
 3. **WITHIN 3 DAYS:** Get the Service Agreement signed. No more work without it.
 4. **WITHIN 7 DAYS:** Collect Phase 1 payment (\$4,000 or negotiated amount)
 5. **WITHIN 14 DAYS:** Get written approval for Phase 2 scope and first milestone payment before starting any work
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THE BOTTOM LINE

You built something genuinely impressive. The website is premium. The animations are professional. The mobile optimization is thorough. The SEO is solid. You should be proud of the work.

But pride doesn’t pay bills. You need a contract, an invoice, and a payment. Today. Not next week. Today.

The friend dynamic, the first-client eagerness, the “I’ll figure out the business stuff later” mentality — these are the #1 killers of freelance careers. The best developers who fail don’t fail because of bad code. They fail because they never learned to ask for money.

You have the technical skills. Now act like a business.